

Aug 24 - Written By Mark Auslander

Honoring the Memory of Frances Poindexter of Georgetown

by Mark Auslander

We are delighted that the headstone of **Mrs. Frances Poindexter**, b 1852, d 3 February 1916, is being returned this week to Mount Zion-Female Union Band Society Cemetery in Georgetown Washington DC, after an apparent absence of several decades. The headstone is recorded in the 1975 survey of the cemetery, in the far northwestern corner of Section II, just southeast of the headstone of Jennie Lynch, France's granddaughter, which still stands. We assume that at some point between 1976 and 2015, Frances' headstone was removed and kept in private possession, perhaps for decades, for reasons that are currently unknown..

1975 cemetery map showing in upper right position of the Jennie Lynch and Frances Poindexter stones

The first census record we see of Frances is 1880, showing her residing at 38 Beall Street (later O) street in Georgetown, with two daughters, "RJ", who must be **Rebecca**, age 12, and **Caldonia**, six years old.

Frances later appears in the 1910 census in Georgetown. She is widowed, age 61, born in Virginia, residing in the household of her daughter Caldonia Poindexter Lynch and Caldonia's three children

Jennie, John, and Henry, at 1032 33rd street in Georgetown, abutting Cady's Alley. This location is immediately north of the C & O canal and one block south of the present day location of the Department of Motor Vehicles.

Frances' Husband Nelson Poindexter

I have not seen a marriage record of Frances and her husband **Nelson Poindexter** (c 1840-1897). The couple is referenced from time to time in the local press, and may have been in a common law marriage. We are not sure of France's maiden name.

Nelson Poindexter, also born in Virginia, appears in the District of Columbia as early as 1 July 1863 in draft registration records; it does not appear he ever served in the military during the Civil War. An 1866 Freedman's Bureau record in DC records him as single, residing alone. I am not sure when he became attached to Frances: but their daughter Caldonia Poindexter was born in or around May 1874, according to the census records, although her headstone lists the birth year at 1882.

I do not see Nelson in the 1870 or 1880 censuses. City directories and newspaper reports suggest he lived his adult life working as a laborer, primarily residing in Georgetown, in the historically Black neighborhoods of Cherry Hill near the Canal and later Herring Hill. near present day Rose Park.

Nelson Poindexter died 25 May 1897 and on 28 May was interred in Mount Zion Cemetery.

Frances in Local Police Records

Frances' daughter **Caldonia Poindexter** (1874-1959) was born in May 1874. From around this time onwards Frances makes frequent appearances in local newspapers as the victim or alleged perpetrator of various crimes and infractions. On 3 April 1874, she is recorded as

having been assaulted by a James Wood. On 17 November 1875, she is accused of assaulting her neighbor Emily Payne in Cherry's Alley (the Cherry Hill neighborhood was a longtime Black neighborhood near the C & O Canal). On 20 October 1877, Frances charges four local women with having assaulted her.

On 26 April 1880, Frances and a small child fell (perhaps Caldonia or Rebecca) down the long flight of steps leading into "Beckett's Hall", and were both seriously injured. This must be a misspelled reference to the household and store of the Black merchant and provisioner Clement Beckett, 1809-1901 who resided at 36 Beall (later 2617 O) street, adjacent to where Frances resided at 38 Beall. Beckett, an important community leader in Black Georgetown, played a founding role in AME Ebenezer and is buried in the Female Union Band Society cemetery. He appears as early as the 1840 census as a free Black man in Georgetown, and is listed variously as a gardener and feed merchant in subsequent records.

On 27 August 1881, Frances husband Nelson Poindexter is convicted of having assaulted Frances. On 27 April 1882, she is convicted of cursing and swearing on the street (sentenced to five dollars or 15 days on the workfarm).

At times local newspapers treat her frequent appearances in the Georgetown police station as a topic of merriment. On 23 May 1883, the National Republication reports, "Frances Poindexter, one of the regular habitues of the third precinct station, went on the war path yesterday evening and attempted to "clean out" Congress alley, but was frustrated by Officers Robey and Riley, who escorted her to her usual couch in the station house."

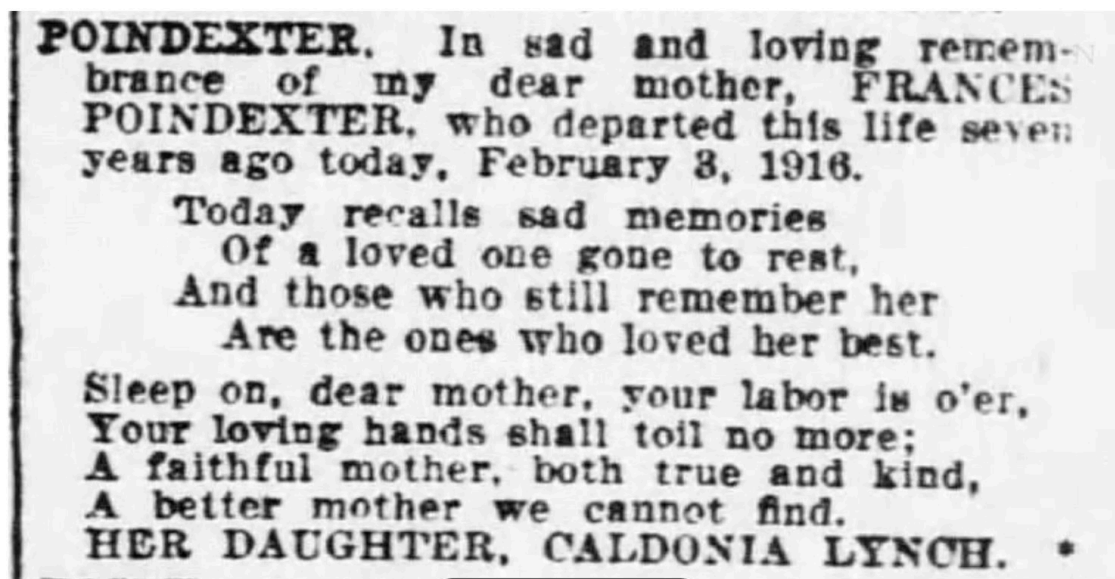
Two months later, on 10 July 1883, she is convicted of disorderly conduct. Eight years later her husband Nelson is convicted of assaulting her by having thrown a bucket at her head. (In his defense

he claimed she had thrown a bucket of water while he was asleep.) On 25 April 1892, unspecified offense, fined eight dollars or 24 days. On 25 July 1893, she is jailed two weeks for disturbing the peace on Cissell's Alley, now Cecil Place in Georgetown, located south of the Canal just west of Wisconsin Avenue. (Her husband Nelson in 1894 is recorded as residing at 1 Cissell Alley.)

Four years after her husband Nelson's death in 1897, Frances makes a brief appearance in local newspaper on 11 June 1891; James Brooks is convicted of striking her in the mouth with his fist.

On 1 November 1907, the Evening Star reports a fire at Frances' residence at 3116 Brickyard Hill in Georgetown, caused by a defective flue.

Frances died on 3 February 1916, at the residence of her daughter Caldonia and son in law, John Lynch, 1026 33rd street in Georgetown, and was buried at the Female Union Band Society cemetery.



POINDEXTER. In sad and loving remembrance of my dear mother, **FRANCES POINDEXTER**, who departed this life seven years ago today, February 3, 1916.

Today recalls sad memories
Of a loved one gone to rest,
And those who still remember her
Are the ones who loved her best.

Sleep on, dear mother, your labor is o'er,
Your loving hands shall toil no more;
A faithful mother, both true and kind,
A better mother we cannot find.
HER DAUGHTER, CALDONIA LYNCH. *

View Newspaper

8 Feb 1923, Evening Star. Caldonia Lynch's memorial for her mother Frances Poindexter

Remembering Frances

Seven years later, in 1923, Frances' daughter Caldonia Poindexter Lynch placed this memorial in the Evening Star

In sad and loving memory of my dear mother Frances Poindexter, who departed this life seven years ago today, February 8, 1916

Today recall sad memories

of a loved one gone to rest

And those who still remember her

are the ones who loved her best

Sleep on, dear mother, your labor is o'er

Your loving hands shall toil no more;

A faithful mother, but true and kind

A better mother we cannot find

HER DAUGHTER CALDONIA LYNCH

For the tenth anniversary of her mother's death, a daughter, presumably also Caldonia.. placed another memorial in the Star:

In sad but loving remembrance of my dear mother Frances Poindexter, who departed this life ten years ago today, February 3, 1916

In our hearts your memory lingers

Sweetly, tender fond and true

There is not one day dear mother

That we do not think of you

LOVING DAUGHTER

Rebecca Poindexter Turner

Rebecca Poindexter, born around 1868, is referenced in a 24 July 1893 article in the Washington Post. She, her mother, and father Nelson Poindexter are arrested for having been part of a noisy household in Cherry Alley. Fourteen years later, on 27 April 1907, Rebecca married a **Charles H Turner** in Washington DC. I do not know if the groom was related to the prominent Black Georgetown, Charles Henry Turner (1856–1939), emancipated in 1862 as the former slave of Mary Darne.

She appears to be the same Rebecca Turner, born in Virginia who died on 31 December 1907, residing at 1045 Potomac street in Georgetown, buried in Mount Zion West (that is to say Female Union Band Cemetery) Potomac Street is adjacent to Cherry Alley, where the Poindexters at times resided. Speculatively, given that this death date is about seven months after the marriage, it may be that Rebecca perished from pregnancy complications.

Caldonia Poindexter Lynch

Caldonia herself had married on 21 May 1895 John Lynch (Sr) , b 1876. In 1900, as noted above, the couple resided at 1026 33rd street, just north of the Canal, in the home family members were to occupy for decades. The couple's children included **Jennie Lynch**, 1897–1920; **John Lynch**, 1900–1945, and **Henry J "Gus" Lynch**, 1902–1891., (John Lynch Sr seems to have died at some point between 1913 and 1919, when Caldonia is listed as a widow.) In 1920, the widowed Caldonia was still residing at 1026 33rd, with her three adult children.

Caldonia after her husband's death worked as a grocer and a cook.

Caldonia's daughter Jennie, sadly, died young, on 31 January 1920, Her headstone, placed a few yards from her grandmother Frances' marker,

still stands and reads: Angels get my mansions ready, for we are crossing the misting river one by one.

John Lynch, Jr, in turn married on 7 March 1918, Pearl Fletcher, daughter of Julia Fletcher. The couple's first child Thelma Lynch, born 1918, died as a five year old child, 3 November 1923 and is buried in Mount Zion. John later remarried, to Helen Cecilia Curtis, who I believe brought a son, James A Curtis (later Lynch) into the marriage

The new couple's children included:

John D Lynch Jr b 1933

Thelma C Lynch, b 1937–2006, who was evidently named for her late half sister.

Roland Lynch, b 1939

Gail Lynch, b 1942

Gloria C Lynch, b 1945

John appears to have been celebrated as the manager of the Black Georgetown baseball team, under the nickname of John "Fatty" Lynch, and to have been the owner of Fatty Lynch's Beer Garden in Georgetown. His occupation is various listed as a truck driver and restaurant cook. During early World War II he resided and lived at Connie's Inn, 1079 Wisconsin Avenue in Georgetown. By the time of his death in 1945, he lived 121 R Street, NE.

When John died on 9 September 1945, death notices indicate that he was a member of at least two Masonic orders; The Jonathan Davis Consistory No 1 and Harmony Lodge FAM. He was funeralized at Metropolitan Baptist Church and buried at Mount Zion cemetery;

His mother Caldonia appears to have commissioned his headstone. Above his name is engraved Caldonia Lynch, with her birth year 1882, and her death year left blank. Although she clearly intended to be buried in Mount Zion, she lived until 1959, by which time Mt Zion had been closed to burials. She was thus buried in Lincoln Cemetery.

Her last address is listed as 1034 33rd street, the same house in which her mother Frances Poindexter had died 43 years earlier.

We are deeply moved that Frances' headstone is finally being returned to its rightful place and are eager to learn more about the family's history in Georgetown and beyond.

Joseph Kellogg's
Early Life in Slavery
and Freedom, Forsyth
County, Georgia

In Search of Four Year
Old Enslaved Harriet:
Rescued from John
Witherow Brown in
1830

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